

WTS · CENTRAL CALIFORNIA

Mentorship

Program Handbook

2026–27 Fiscal Year

Empowering Women in Transportation

A program of WTS International · Central California Chapter

WELCOME FROM THE MENTORSHIP CHAIR

Welcome to the WTS-CenCal Mentorship Program. This program was built from scratch for the 2026–27 program year with one clear goal: to create intentional, structured connections between early-career women in transportation and the experienced professionals who can help them navigate, grow, and thrive.

Mentorship at its best is not transactional. It is a relationship built on trust, curiosity, and mutual respect. Whether you are stepping into the role of mentor or mentee, you are making an investment — in another person, and in the future of our industry.

This handbook is your guide. Read it, keep it, and refer back to it. If you have questions at any point, reach out to the Mentorship Committee.

Laurie Hopelian

Chair, Mentorship Committee

WTS-CenCal · Achievement Engineering Corporation

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ABOUT THE PROGRAM

The WTS-CenCal Mentorship Program is a structured, year-long program that connects active members of the WTS Central California chapter in mentor-mentee pairs. The program is designed specifically for early-career women in transportation-related fields — engineering, planning, project management, business development, and related disciplines.

Program Year

April 1, 2026 – March 31, 2027 (Cohort 1 launched Spring 2026)

Program Goals

- Create meaningful, structured mentorship relationships within the WTS-CenCal community
- Support the professional development of early-career women in transportation
- Build a stronger, more connected chapter through peer relationships
- Establish a repeatable program infrastructure that can scale with the chapter

Who Is This Program For?

Mentees: Early-career women in transportation-related fields (typically 0–7 years of experience) who are WTS-CenCal members or student affiliates. You do not need to have all the answers. You just need to show up.

Mentors: Experienced professionals (typically 8+ years) who are active WTS-CenCal members and want to give back. You do not need to be an expert in every area. You just need to be willing to share what you know.

WHAT IS EXPECTED OF YOU

Time Commitment

The program runs for approximately 12 months. At minimum, matched pairs are expected to meet four times during the program year — roughly once per quarter. Each meeting should be at least 45–60 minutes.

Beyond scheduled meetings, participants are encouraged to stay in light touch between sessions — a brief check-in message, sharing a relevant article, or acknowledging a professional milestone goes a long way.

Mentor Responsibilities

- Show up prepared and on time to scheduled meetings
- Listen actively and ask questions before giving advice
- Share your professional journey honestly — including the hard parts
- Introduce your mentee to relevant contacts when appropriate
- Log your check-ins in the Mentorship Portal after each meeting
- Respond to communications within 5 business days
- Attend at least one WTS-CenCal program event during the year

Mentee Responsibilities

- Take ownership of scheduling — you drive the relationship
- Come to each meeting with an agenda or specific questions
- Be open to feedback, even when it is uncomfortable
- Follow through on commitments made in meetings
- Log your check-ins in the Mentorship Portal after each meeting
- Respond to communications within 3 business days
- Attend at least one WTS-CenCal program event during the year

Confidentiality

What is shared in the mentorship relationship stays in the mentorship relationship. Neither party should share the other's personal or professional information outside of the program without explicit permission.

PROGRAM TIMELINE

When	Milestone	Details
March 2026	Applications Open	Intake forms available on the Mentorship Portal. Both mentors and mentees apply.
April 2026	Cohort 1 Matching	Mentorship Committee reviews applications and creates pairs based on interests, geography, and goals.
April 2026	Match Notification	Matched pairs receive an introduction email with each other's profiles and next steps.
May 2026	Speed Mentoring Event	Open to all WTS-CenCal members. Great for those still deciding whether to apply.
July 2026	Q1 Check-In Deadline	All pairs log their first two check-ins in the portal.
October 2026	Cohort 2 Applications Open	Second cohort intake begins for the January 2027 match.
January 2027	Annual Recognition Dinner	Year-end celebration honoring mentors, mentees, and program milestones.
March 2027	Program Year Closes	Final check-ins logged. Alumni status offered to continuing participants.

HOW MATCHING WORKS

The Mentorship Committee reviews all applications and creates pairs manually, taking into account the following factors:

- Discipline alignment (e.g., engineering, planning, business development)
- Career stage and experience gap
- Geographic proximity or willingness to meet virtually
- Stated goals and interests
- Availability and meeting preference

Matching is not an exact science. The committee will make its best judgment. If at any point a match does not feel right — for any reason — participants should contact the Mentorship Chair to discuss a rematch. No explanation is required.

USING THE MENTORSHIP PORTAL

The WTS-CenCal Mentorship Portal is the program's central platform. Participants log in with their email address (no password required). From the portal you can:

- View your match's profile
- Log check-ins after each meeting
- Update your profile and preferences
- RSVP to program events
- Access the Resource Library (this handbook, worksheets, templates)
- Read chapter announcements

Access the portal at the URL provided in your welcome email. If you have trouble logging in, contact the Mentorship Chair.

CONTACT & SUPPORT

The Mentorship Committee is here to support you throughout the program year. Do not wait until something is a problem to reach out — early communication makes everything easier.

Program Chair	Laurie Hopelian · laurie@achievang.com
Chapter Secretary	Rachel Pevsner · rachel@achievang.com
WTS-CenCal General	wtsccal@gmail.com
WTS International	wtsinternational.org

Thank you for being part of this program. We are building something meaningful together.